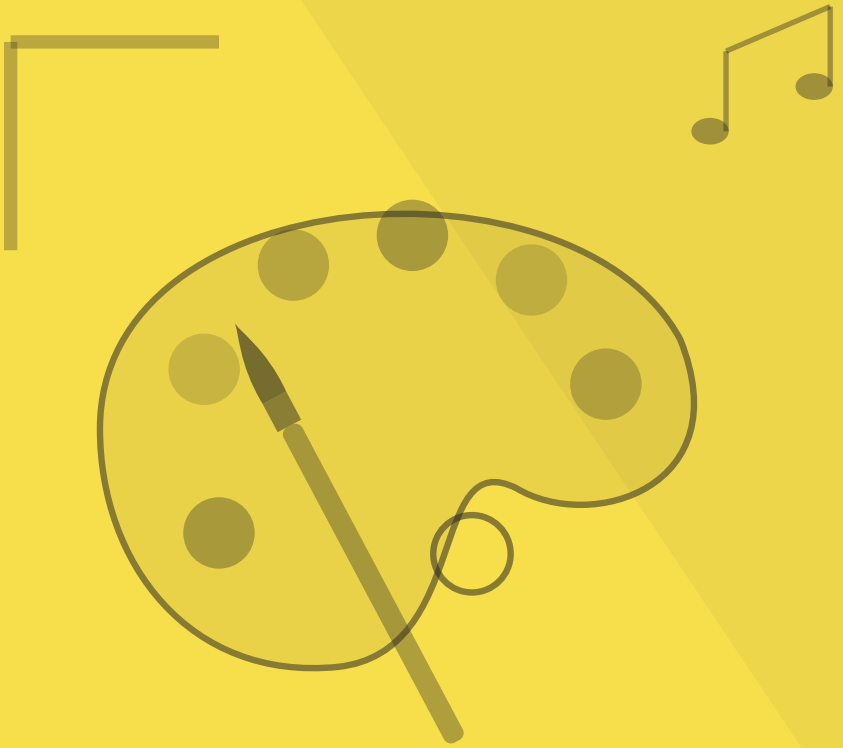
VENVLEARNING

STUDENT TEXTBOOK



Art

GRADE 7

Lessons, examples, and practice for the whole year

2026–2027 School Year · Unit 1: The Elements of Art

VENVLEARNING

Grade 7
Art

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

2026–2027 School Year

Unit 1 The Elements of Art

This book belongs to _____

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this book

Each lesson starts with an I can goal and a Look And Wonder question. Read the lesson with your teacher. Read about the idea, study the Step by Step demonstrations, then make art in the Create studio activity. Your practice pages are in your Student Workbook, labeled with the same lesson number.

- Key Idea boxes hold the most important rule or fact. Learn these.
- Watch Out boxes warn you about common mistakes.
- Create boxes are studio activities. Keep everything you make in your portfolio folder.
- Every Friday there is a short Sketchbook Check in your workbook. The last Friday of a unit is the Portfolio Review.

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UNIT 1

The Elements of Art

Critique, line and mark-making, form and light, proportion, color schemes, chiaroscuro, composition, and the artist statement.

Skilled artists combine sharp eyes with deliberate choices. In this unit you'll learn a professional critique method, build drawing skills (mark-making, light logic, proportion), use color theory and dramatic value, plan strong compositions, and finish a revised work with an artist statement.

In this unit you will...

- Critique art using describe, analyze, interpret, judge.
- Use contour, gesture, and value techniques; render light on forms.
- Apply proportion, color schemes, and chiaroscuro.
- Plan compositions, revise with critique, and write an artist statement.

ART IN YOUR WORLD

Illustrators, game artists, photographers, and filmmakers use light, color, and composition to steer attention and emotion.

UNIT VOCABULARY

critique	Structured discussion of art.
hatching	Parallel lines for value.
chiaroscuro	Strong light-dark contrast.
analogous	Neighboring colors.
rule of thirds	Placing key elements on thirds.
artist statement	Explanation of an artwork.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
1.1	Looking Closely: The Four-Step Critique

Lesson	Title
1.2	Line and Mark-Making
1.3	Form and Light
1.4	Proportion and the Human Figure
1.5	Color Theory and Color Schemes
1.6	Value, Contrast, and Chiaroscuro
1.7	Composition: Thirds, Leading Lines, and Balance
1.8	Revision, Critique, and the Artist Statement

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.1 · NCAS VA:Re7, VA:Re8, VA:Re9

Lesson 1.1: Looking Closely: The Four-Step Critique

I can analyze an artwork using describe, analyze, interpret, and judge.

WORDS TO KNOW

elements of art	Line, shape, form, color, value, texture, and space.
principles of design	How artists arrange the elements: balance, contrast, emphasis, movement, pattern, rhythm, unity, and proportion.
critique	A structured, thoughtful discussion of an artwork.
interpret	To explain what an artwork means or expresses.

LOOK AND WONDER

Why do people disagree about whether an artwork is "good"? Can an opinion about art be supported with evidence?

Art critic Edmund Feldman described a four-step method that moves from facts to opinions, so judgments rest on evidence:

Describe: what do you see? (facts only) → Analyze: how are the elements and principles used? → Interpret: what does it mean or express? → Judge: is it successful? Why?

Practice on The Migration Series (1940–41) by Jacob Lawrence, a set of 60 small paintings about the Great Migration of African Americans from the rural South to Northern cities, the same history you read about in ELA. Lawrence used a limited palette of bold, flat colors and repeated shapes, so the whole series reads like one story. Many panels can be viewed online through the Phillips Collection and the Museum of Modern Art, which each own half of the series.

STEP BY STEP · CRITIQUE ONE PANEL

Choose any panel from The Migration Series.

1. Describe: list figures, objects, colors, and words in the caption.
2. Analyze: find repeated shapes, strong diagonals, or the limited color palette.
3. Interpret: what feeling or message does the panel express about the migration?
4. Judge: does it communicate that message well? Give evidence from steps 1–3.

Look for: A judgment that grows from description and analysis is persuasive, even if others disagree.

CREATE · CRITIQUE PRACTICE

Can you support an opinion about art with evidence?

You need: internet access or an art book; sketchbook.

1 Choose one Migration Series panel.

2 Write two sentences for each critique step.

3 Make a quick thumbnail sketch of the panel's composition (just the main shapes).

Record: your four-step critique and thumbnail.

KEY IDEA

Describe, analyze, interpret, judge: build opinions about art on evidence.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Which critique step lists facts only?
2. Which step explains meaning?
3. What did The Migration Series depict?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.1.

LESSON SUMMARY

Describe, analyze, interpret, judge.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.2 · NCAS VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.2: Line and Mark-Making

I can use contour, gesture, hatching, cross-hatching, and stippling to describe form and value.

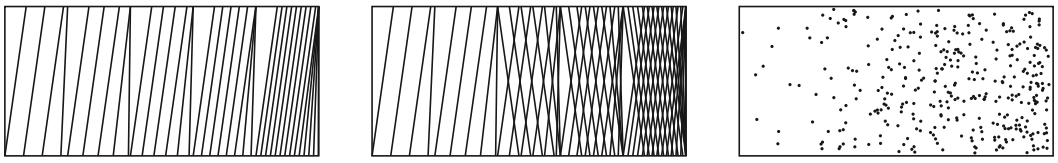
WORDS TO KNOW

contour drawing	A drawing of an object's edges, made with careful, continuous line.
gesture drawing	A quick drawing that captures movement and pose.
hatching	Parallel lines that create value; cross-hatching layers them in different directions.
stippling	Dots that create value; closer dots look darker.

LOOK AND WONDER

How can a drawing made only of black lines show light and shadow?

Line can describe edges, movement, and even value. A contour line traces edges slowly. A blind contour, drawn without looking at the paper, trains your eye to see. A gesture drawing captures movement in seconds. To build value with line, artists use hatching, cross-hatching, and stippling.



hatching cross-hatching stippling

The German artist Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) was a master of hatching in engravings and woodcuts. In his woodcut Rhinoceros (1515), patterns of lines create both texture and value, even though Dürer never saw the animal; he worked from a written description and a sketch by someone else.

CREATE · MARK-MAKING VALUE STUDIES

Which technique makes the smoothest value change?

You need: fine black pen or sharp pencil; sketchbook.

1. Draw three rectangles divided into five boxes.
2. Fill one with hatching, one with cross-hatching, and one with stippling, light to dark.
3. Draw a 2-minute blind contour of your hand.
4. Draw your hand again, looking, and shade it with one technique.

Record: the three value strips and two hand drawings.

KEY IDEA

Line can describe edges (contour), movement (gesture), and value (hatching, cross-hatching, stippling).

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What is hatching?
2. Which technique uses dots?
3. Why do blind contours?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.2.

LESSON SUMMARY

Contour, gesture, hatching, cross-hatching, stippling.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.3 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Cr3

Lesson 1.3: Form and Light

I can render a form using a consistent light source with highlight, midtone, core shadow, reflected light, and cast shadow.

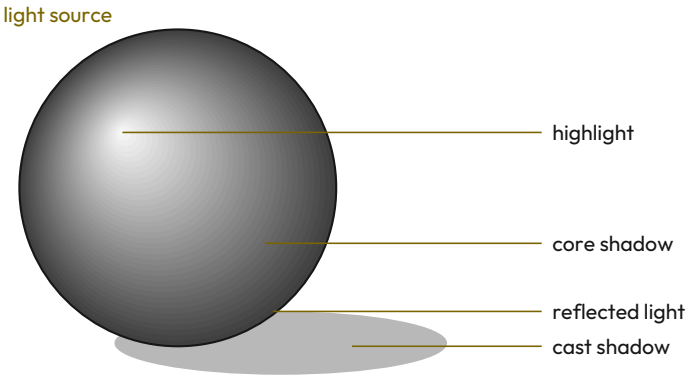
WORDS TO KNOW

light source	The direction light comes from.
highlight	The brightest spot, where light hits most directly.
core shadow	The darkest part on the form, turned away from the light.
reflected light	Dim light bounced back onto the shadow side from nearby surfaces.
cast shadow	The shadow an object throws onto another surface.

LOOK AND WONDER

Shine a flashlight on a ball in a dark room. Where is it brightest? Where is it darkest? Is the edge of the shadow side completely black?

Realistic drawing depends on light logic: every form in a picture is lit from the same direction. On a sphere, value changes gradually from the highlight through the midtones to the core shadow. Near the edge of the shadow side, light bounces back from the table as reflected light. The darkest dark is usually the cast shadow right where the object touches the surface.



CREATE · STILL LIFE WITH ONE LIGHT

Can you render three forms lit the same way?

You need: a ball, a box, and a can or cup; flashlight or desk lamp; pencils (2H, HB, 4B if you have them); blending stump or tissue.

1 Arrange the objects and light them from one side in a dim room.

2 Lightly draw their shapes and the cast shadows.

3 Squint to see the value groups; shade from light to dark.

4 Check: is the light coming from the same side on every object?

Record: your rendered still life with the light direction marked by an arrow.

KEY IDEA

Keep one light source. Render highlight, midtone, core shadow, reflected light, and cast shadow.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Where is the darkest part of a cast shadow?

2. Why is reflected light dimmer than the lit side?

3. What goes wrong with two light directions?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.3.

LESSON SUMMARY

One light source; five parts of light on every form.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.4 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Cn11

Lesson 1.4: Proportion and the Human Figure

I can use proportion guidelines to draw a face and a standing figure.

WORDS TO KNOW

proportion	Size relationships between parts and the whole.
canon of proportion	A set of rules for ideal body proportions.
foreshortening	Drawing an object that points toward the viewer so it looks shorter.

LOOK AND WONDER

How many of your head-heights tall do you think you are? Guess, then measure with a partner.

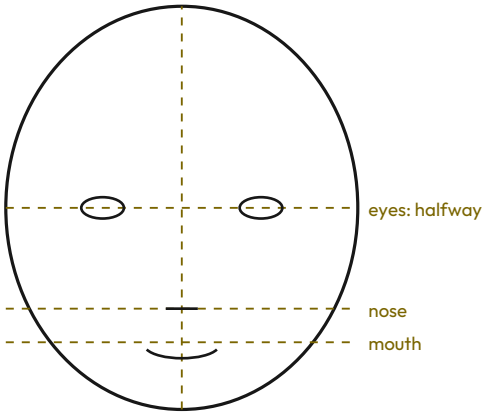
Artists have measured the body for thousands of years. Around 1490, Leonardo da Vinci drew the Vitruvian Man, a figure inside a circle and a square, based on the Roman architect Vitruvius's ideas about ideal proportions. Today artists often use the head as a unit: an adult is roughly 7½ heads tall (fashion and comic illustrators often stretch it to 8 or more).

On the face, the eyes sit about halfway down the head.

The bottom of the nose is about halfway between the eyes and the chin; the mouth is about a third of the way from nose to chin.

The tops of the ears line up with the brow; the bottoms with the nose.

On the body, the hips are near the halfway point, and the fingertips reach mid-thigh.



CREATE · MEASURED PORTRAIT AND FIGURE

Do proportion rules match real people?

You need: pencil; measuring tape; mirror; a partner or a photo.

1. Measure a partner's head height and total height; divide to find “heads tall.”
2. Draw a proportional face with guidelines from the mirror.
3. Draw a standing figure 7½ heads tall using stacked ovals as a guide.

4 Compare the rule with your measurements.

Record: measurements, the face, and the figure.

KEY IDEA

Use the head as a unit: eyes halfway down the head, an adult about 7½ heads tall. Measure real people to test the rules.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. About how many heads tall is an adult?
2. Who drew the Vitruvian Man?
3. Where do the ears line up?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.4.

LESSON SUMMARY

The head is the unit: eyes halfway, adult about 7½ heads.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.5 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Re8

Lesson 1.5: Color Theory and Color Schemes

I can describe hue, saturation, and value, and use color schemes to create mood.

WORDS TO KNOW

hue	The name of a color on the wheel (red, blue-green).
saturation	How intense or dull a color is (also called intensity).
complementary	Colors opposite on the wheel.
analogous	Colors next to each other on the wheel.
triadic	Three colors evenly spaced around the wheel.

LOOK AND WONDER

Why do sunsets feel warm and oceans feel calm? Is it the color, or what we associate with it?

Every color has three properties: hue (its name), value (light or dark), and saturation (bright or dull). Mixing a color with its complement lowers saturation, making it duller or grayer. Artists choose color schemes to set a mood.



Blue and orange are complements: opposite on the wheel.

Scheme	Colors	Effect
monochromatic	tints and shades of one hue	unified, calm
analogous	3–4 neighbors (yellow, yellow-green, green)	harmonious, natural
complementary	opposites (blue and orange)	high contrast, energetic
split-complementary	one hue + the two neighbors of its complement	contrast with less tension
triadic	three evenly spaced hues (red, yellow, blue)	lively, balanced
warm / cool	reds, oranges, yellows / blues, greens, violets	warm advances; cool recedes

CREATE · ONE IMAGE, TWO MOODS

How does a color scheme change meaning?

You need: colored pencils, markers, or paint; two copies of a simple line drawing.

1 Draw a simple scene (a house and tree) and trace it twice.

2 Color one in an analogous warm scheme.

3 Color the other in a complementary or cool scheme.

4 Write the mood of each.

Record: both versions and a sentence about how mood changed.

KEY IDEA

Hue, value, and saturation describe any color. Color schemes control harmony, contrast, and mood.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Complement of red
2. Analogous colors are...
3. How do you lower a color's saturation?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.5.

LESSON SUMMARY

Hue, value, saturation; schemes create mood.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.6 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Re7

Lesson 1.6: Value, Contrast, and Chiaroscuro

I can make a nine-step value scale and use strong contrast (chiaroscuro) for drama.

WORDS TO KNOW

value scale	A sequence of even steps from white to black.
chiaroscuro	Italian for “light-dark”: strong contrast between light and shadow.
tenebrism	Extreme chiaroscuro, with figures emerging from deep darkness.

LOOK AND WONDER

Watch a scary movie scene with the sound off. How does lighting create the mood?

A value scale is a ruler for darkness. Artists train by making even steps from white to black, then use that control to model forms.



white black

Italian painters of the Renaissance and Baroque periods used chiaroscuro to make figures look solid and dramatic. Caravaggio (1571–1610) pushed it to extremes, called tenebrism: in The Calling of Saint Matthew (about 1600), a beam of light cuts across a dark room and lands on the faces of the men at the table. Rembrandt later used warm, glowing light against deep shadow in his portraits.

CREATE · DRAMATIC LIGHT STUDY

How does strong side lighting change an object?

You need: one object (a mug, an apple, a toy); flashlight; dark paper and white charcoal or chalk, or pencil on white paper.

1 Make a nine-step value scale.

2 Light your object from one low side in a dark room.

3 Draw it, pushing the darks very dark and saving the lights.

4 Compare with a drawing of the same object in flat, even light.

Record: value scale and both drawings.

KEY IDEA

Control value with even steps; strong light-dark contrast (chiaroscuro) creates drama and solidity.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What does chiaroscuro mean?

2. Which artist is known for tenebrism?

3. How many steps in the class value scale?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.6.

LESSON SUMMARY

Even value steps; chiaroscuro for drama.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.7 · NCAS VA:Cr1, VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.7: Composition: Thirds, Leading Lines, and Balance

I can plan a composition using the rule of thirds, leading lines, emphasis, and asymmetrical balance.

WORDS TO KNOW

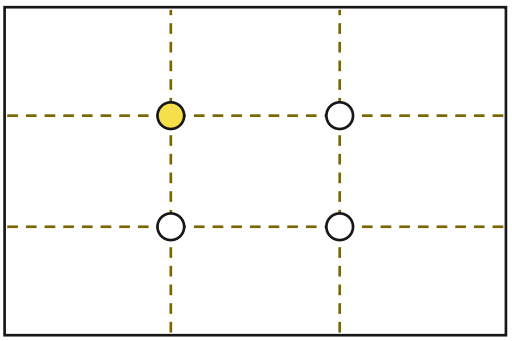
rule of thirds	Dividing an image into thirds and placing key elements on the lines or crossings.
leading lines	Lines that guide the eye toward the focal point.
negative space	The empty space around and between objects.
asymmetrical balance	Different elements arranged so visual weight feels even.

LOOK AND WONDER

Where does your eye go first in a movie poster? What tricks get it there?

Strong compositions guide the viewer. The rule of thirds places the focal point near one of four crossing points instead of dead center.

Leading lines (roads, rivers, arms, edges) point the eye to it. Asymmetrical balance keeps the picture interesting, and negative space gives the subject room to breathe.



In The Great Wave off Kanagawa (about 1831), Katsushika Hokusai builds a powerful asymmetrical composition: the giant wave fills the left and top, its claw-like crest leads the eye across to tiny Mount Fuji, and the boats curve along the wave's path. The small mountain balances the huge wave.

CREATE · FOUR THUMBNAILS

Which composition tells your idea best?

You need: pencil; sketchbook.

1. Choose a subject that matters to you.
2. Draw four thumbnails: centered, rule of thirds, strong leading lines, and lots of negative space.
3. Shade each in three values (light, middle, dark) only.

4 Pick the strongest and write why.

Record: four value thumbnails and your choice.

KEY IDEA

Place the focal point thoughtfully, lead the eye to it, balance asymmetrically, and use negative space.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What are leading lines?
2. What balances the great wave in Hokusai's print?
3. Why value-only thumbnails?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.7.

LESSON SUMMARY

Thirds, leading lines, balance, negative space.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.8 · NCAS VA:Cr3, VA:Pr5, VA:Re9

Lesson 1.8: Revision, Critique, and the Artist Statement

I can revise a work using peer critique and write an artist statement explaining my choices.

WORDS TO KNOW

artist statement	A short text in which an artist explains their work, process, and choices.
peer critique	Structured feedback from classmates or family.

LOOK AND WONDER

Have you ever read the small card next to a painting in a museum? What makes one interesting to read?

Develop your best thumbnail into a finished piece. Midway, hold a short critique using three prompts: I notice… (description), I wonder… (a question), What if… (a suggestion). Then revise.

Finish with an artist statement of 75–150 words: what you made, the elements and principles you used and why, what you changed after feedback, and what you want viewers to feel or think.

STEP BY STEP · ARTIST STATEMENT STARTER

A charcoal drawing of a grandmother's hands

1 What: “This charcoal drawing shows my grandmother's hands holding a quilt square.”

2 How: “I used chiaroscuro and a rule-of-thirds composition, with the quilt's lines leading to her hands.”

3 Revision: “After feedback, I darkened the background so the hands stand out.”

4 Meaning: “I want viewers to see how hands carry family stories.”

Look for: Clear, specific, and personal.

CREATE · FINAL PIECE AND STATEMENT

Can you finish, critique, revise, and explain a work?

You need: your chosen thumbnail; drawing paper; your choice of media.

1 Develop the thumbnail into a final work.

2 Hold a critique with I notice / I wonder / What if.

3 Revise.

4 Write your artist statement.

Record: your final piece and statement for the portfolio.

KEY IDEA

Critique with I notice / I wonder / What if; revise; explain your choices in an artist statement.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Name the three critique prompts.

2. How long is the artist statement?

3. Name two things an artist statement includes.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.8.

LESSON SUMMARY

Critique, revise, and explain your choices.

UNIT 1 REVIEW

Unit 1 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember…
1.1	Describe, analyze, interpret, judge.
1.2	Contour, gesture, hatching, cross-hatching, stippling.
1.3	One light source; five parts of light on every form.
1.4	The head is the unit: eyes halfway, adult about 7½ heads.
1.5	Hue, value, saturation; schemes create mood.
1.6	Even value steps; chiaroscuro for drama.
1.7	Thirds, leading lines, balance, negative space.
1.8	Critique, revise, and explain your choices.

Glossary

analogous	Neighboring colors.
artist statement	Explanation of an artwork.
asymmetrical balance	Different elements arranged so visual weight feels even.
canon of proportion	A set of rules for ideal body proportions.
cast shadow	The shadow an object throws onto another surface.
chiaroscuro	Strong light-dark contrast.
complementary	Colors opposite on the wheel.
contour drawing	A drawing of an object's edges, made with careful, continuous line.
core shadow	The darkest part on the form, turned away from the light.
critique	Structured discussion of art.
elements of art	Line, shape, form, color, value, texture, and space.
foreshortening	Drawing an object that points toward the viewer so it looks shorter.
gesture drawing	A quick drawing that captures movement and pose.
hatching	Parallel lines for value.
highlight	The brightest spot, where light hits most directly.
hue	The name of a color on the wheel (red, blue-green).
interpret	To explain what an artwork means or expresses.
leading lines	Lines that guide the eye toward the focal point.
light source	The direction light comes from.
negative space	The empty space around and between objects.
peer critique	Structured feedback from classmates or family.
principles of design	How artists arrange the elements: balance, contrast, emphasis, movement, pattern, rhythm, unity, and proportion.
proportion	Size relationships between parts and the whole.
reflected light	Dim light bounced back onto the shadow side from nearby surfaces.
rule of thirds	Placing key elements on thirds.
saturation	How intense or dull a color is (also called intensity).
stippling	Dots that create value; closer dots look darker.
tenebrism	Extreme chiaroscuro, with figures emerging from deep darkness.

triadic	Three colors evenly spaced around the wheel.
value scale	A sequence of even steps from white to black.

Grade 7 Art

Student Textbook · 2026–2027

A full year of Grade 7 arts: drawing, painting, and design; music; art history; theater and dance; media arts; and sculpture. Every lesson pairs looking closely at real artwork with hands-on studio time, and the year ends with a portfolio and a show.

This Student Textbook teaches every lesson: the big idea, key vocabulary, models and examples, and a short set of practice problems to check understanding. It pairs with the Student Workbook and the Teacher Edition.

INSIDE THIS YEAR

01 The Elements of Art

IN THIS BOOK

- Clear lesson goals: “I can…” statements
- Key vocabulary with student-friendly definitions
- Models, examples, and Key Idea summaries
- A study guide and glossary for every unit

THE COMPLETE SET



Textbook
You are holding this book

Workbook

Teacher Edition

Each lesson has the same number in all three books, and every day of the year is mapped to its lesson in the VenvLearning planner.